



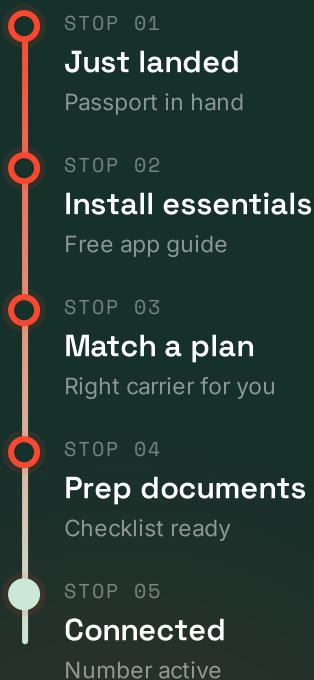
Connect KR

PHONE SETUP · SEOUL

LINE 01 — ARRIVAL → CONNECTED

Get a Korean phone, minus the Korean.

Five personalized activation guides — the exact carrier, plan, documents, and steps for your situation, so you just walk in and hand them over.



EDITION

EN · Batch 1

GUIDES

5 profiles

VERIFIED

Jul 2026

Connect KR prepares your paperwork and guides you — we do not activate the line on your behalf, and approval is up to the carrier, so activation is not guaranteed. Not affiliated with SKT, KT, or LG U+. Prices and documents are estimates that change often.

Short Stay • No ARC • Light Data

The easiest — and cheapest — situation of all.

STAY
Under 1 month

ARC
None yet

DATA
Light • <3GB

PHONE
Own phone

BUDGET
Low • <₩15k

01 Your Custom Plan Strategy

You're here briefly, you barely use data (mostly on Wi-Fi), and you already have an unlocked phone. You do **not** need a Korean number, a contract, or a store visit. The best move is a small **travel eSIM data plan** installed before you land.

A Korean airport prepaid SIM costs ₩50,000–60,000 for 30 days — overkill here. A small eSIM pack gives you exactly what you need for a fraction of that, while your home SIM stays active for your home number.

RECOMMENDED ROUTE

Travel eSIM (data-only)

여행용 데이터 eSIM

₩ EST. COST

₩10,000–15,000

≈ \$8–11 · whole trip

DIFFICULTY

Easy

● ○ ○

⌚ SETUP

~5 min

⚠ **Heads-up** — A data eSIM gives you internet, not a Korean 010 number. For light, short use that's usually all you need — see Warnings if you need to receive a Korean SMS code.

02 Required Documents



eSIM-compatible, unlocked phone

iPhone XS+, Galaxy S20/S21+, Pixel 3+ · not carrier-locked



International payment card

Any Visa/Mastercard to buy the plan online



Passport

Backup ID only — most data eSIMs need no ID

03 Providers & Exactly Where to Go

Airalo airalo.com

Widest-known option; the lowest entry prices for small Korea packs — best fit for your budget.

Saily saily.com

Clean app, reliable Korea coverage; good if you want a slightly bigger buffer.

Yesim yesim.app

Flexible pay-as-you-go alternative.

 You don't go anywhere physical. Everything happens in the app on your phone.

04 Step-by-Step Action Plan

1 Before you fly (on home Wi-Fi)

Open the Airalo app or airalo.com and search "South Korea." The results appear as cards, each showing the data size, number of days, and price. Choose the smallest that fits — around 3GB — with validity covering your whole trip, and tap to buy.

2 Buy and receive your QR code

Pay with your international card. Airalo instantly emails you a QR code with install instructions, and shows the same under "My eSIMs" in the app. Keep that open for the next step.

3 Install the eSIM (still at home)

On your phone: Settings → Cellular / Mobile Data → Add eSIM → "Use QR Code," then scan the code from Airalo. When prompted, label the line "Korea." Leave data roaming for that line OFF for now — it only starts counting on first use in Korea.

4 On landing at Incheon

Once you land, return to Settings, switch the Korea eSIM line on, and set it as your Cellular Data line (your home line can stay on for calls). The Korean carrier name appears in your status bar within a minute — you're online, no counter needed.

5 If you run low

- Buy more data inside the same app under "My eSIMs" → top up. No store visit ever needed.

05 Korean Script for the Clerk

- AT A CAFÉ OR HOTEL

와이파이 비밀번호 좀 알려주세요.

Wa-i-pa-i bi-mil-beon-ho jom al-lyeo-ju-se-yo.

"Could you tell me the Wi-Fi password, please?"

06 Insider Warnings & Hidden Costs

-  **Data eSIM ≠ Korean number.** If you need a Korean 010 number to receive an SMS code, a data eSIM won't do it. Fastest fix: buy a cheap airport prepaid SIM with your passport at the SKT/KT counters in Incheon T1/T2 — but only if you truly need the number.

⚠️ **Confirm your phone is unlocked** at least a week before flying. A locked phone won't accept the eSIM.

⚠️ **eSIM activates on first use, not at purchase.** Install it before the flight, but only **ENABLE** it once you're in Korea.

⚠️ **No refunds once activated.** Buy the smallest plan that fits — you can always top up.

Information last verified: 2026-07-13 · Prices & terms change often — confirm at the source before publishing.

Short Stay • No ARC • Medium Data

A normal traveler's setup: enough data, zero hassle.

STAY
Under 1 month

ARC
None yet

DATA
Medium • 3–10GB

PHONE
Own phone

BUDGET
Medium • ₩15–40k

01 Your Custom Plan Strategy

You use maps, messaging, some music, the occasional video away from Wi-Fi. You want enough data to stop thinking about it, but no contract and no Korean number. The smart move is again a **travel eSIM** — just with a larger bucket (10–20GB).

This lands squarely in budget and beats an airport prepaid SIM on price and convenience. Keep your home number on the physical SIM; let the Korean eSIM carry data.

RECOMMENDED ROUTE

Travel eSIM (bigger bucket)

중용량 데이터 eSIM

₩ EST. COST

₩25,000–38,000

≈ \$19–28 • 30-day pack

DIFFICULTY

Easy

● ○ ○

⌚ SETUP

~5 min

⚠ **Heads-up** — Prefer a Korean number too? An airport prepaid SIM is the alternative (~₩50,000 / 30 days) — slightly above budget, but it includes a number. See Section 3.

02 Required Documents



eSIM-compatible, unlocked phone

iPhone XS+, Galaxy S20/S21+, Pixel 3+



International payment card

Visa/Mastercard



Passport

Backup for eSIM • REQUIRED for the airport prepaid SIM route

03 Providers & Exactly Where to Go

Saily saily.com

Strong 20GB / 30-day value — recommended for your data level.

Airalo airalo.com

Reliable 10GB Korea pack.

Airport prepaid SIM [Incheon T1/T2](#)

If you want a Korean number: SKT booth opposite Gate 13 (24h) & KT/LG U+ counters, T1; SKT booth between Gate 4–5 (24h), T2. Passport, on the spot.

 eSIM: entirely in-app. Prepaid: the arrivals-hall telecom counter after customs (locations above).

04 Step-by-Step Action Plan

1 Route A — eSIM • Before flying

In the Saily app, search "South Korea" and open the plan list. Each plan shows data, days, and price; choose the 20GB / 30-day option and tap to purchase.

2 Route A — Pay & get the QR

Complete the purchase with your card. Saily then shows the QR code and install steps in-app (and by email). Keep them open for the next step.

3 Route A — Install & enable

Settings → Cellular → Add eSIM → scan the QR. Don't enable it until you're in Korea; once you land, set the Korea eSIM as your active Cellular Data line.

4 Route B — Airport prepaid • Find the counter

After clearing customs at Incheon, follow the signs to the telecom / SIM counters in the arrivals hall (exact spots in Section 3). Look for the SKT, KT, or LG U+ counter with "SIM Card / Prepaid" signage.

5 Route B — Show passport, ask for the plan

Hand over your passport and ask for a 30-day prepaid data plan (script in Section 5). Staff scan your passport into the KCC real-name system, then insert and activate the SIM — allow roughly 20–30 minutes for the line to go live. Keep the receipt with your top-up number.

05 Korean Script for the Clerk

• AT THE PREPAID COUNTER

선불 유심 30일 데이터 요금제로 개통하고 싶어요.

Seon-bul yu-sim sam-sib-il de-i-teo yo-geum-je-ro gae-tong-ha-go sip-eo-yo.

"I'd like to activate a 30-day prepaid SIM data plan."

• IF THEY PUSH A CONTRACT

약정 없이 선불로만 할게요.

Yak-jeong eop-si seon-bul-lo-man hal-ge-yo.

"No contract — prepaid only, please."

⚠️ **One line per passport (2026 rule).** After a major SIM-fraud crackdown, Korea now allows only one prepaid line per passport, verified against your physical passport. Don't open a second line for a friend on your ID.

⚠️ **eSIM carries no Korean number.** Route A is data only; choose Route B if a number matters.

⚠️ **Watch the throttle.** Some airport SIMs cap high-speed data then slow down — ask the counter for the daily/period cap before paying.

⚠️ **Keep the SIM in one device.** Airport-activated SIMs are tied to the device used at registration; swapping phones can drop service.

Information last verified: 2026-07-13 · Prices & terms change often — confirm at the source before publishing.

Short Stay • No ARC • Unlimited Data

Heavy user, short trip, budget's not the constraint.

STAY
Under 1 month

ARC
None yet

DATA
Unlimited

PHONE
Own phone

BUDGET
High • ₩40–70k

01 Your Custom Plan Strategy

You're hotspotting a laptop, streaming on the go, taking video calls anywhere — and budget isn't the issue. You want **genuinely unlimited data** with zero counter hassle. The cleanest option is a **premium unlimited travel eSIM**, installed before you land.

Two good paths: an unlimited eSIM (e.g. Holafly) for uncapped data with no number, or an airport prepaid unlimited SIM that adds a Korean number at a similar price. No number needed → go eSIM.

RECOMMENDED ROUTE

Premium unlimited eSIM

프리미엄 무제한 eSIM

₩ EST. COST

₩50,000–65,000

≈ \$38–49 • 30-day unlimited

DIFFICULTY

Easy

● ○ ○

⌚ SETUP

~5 min

⚠ **Heads-up** — Even "unlimited" plans may throttle tethering after a high threshold. If you work off your phone's hotspot, confirm the tethering cap first.

02 Required Documents



eSIM-compatible, unlocked phone

For the eSIM route



International payment card

Visa/Mastercard



Passport

Backup for eSIM • REQUIRED for the airport prepaid route

03 Providers & Exactly Where to Go

Holafly holafly.com

The best-known truly-unlimited Korea eSIM; ~30-day unlimited plan.

Saily / Airalo saily.com · airalo.com

Large-bucket (e.g. 50GB) alternatives if you'd rather have a big cap than "unlimited."

Airport prepaid (data + number) [Incheon T1/T2](#)

Ask for the highest-tier / unlimited 30-day prepaid plan. SKT booth opposite Gate 13 (24h), T1; between Gate 4–5, T2.

 eSIM: in-app. Prepaid: the Incheon arrivals telecom counters (locations above).

04 Step-by-Step Action Plan

1 Route A — Unlimited eSIM • Before flying

On holafly.com, choose "South Korea," then select the unlimited 30-day plan (the page lists the daily / period terms). Add it to the cart and pay with your card.

2 Route A — Purchase → receive QR

After payment, Holafly emails your QR code and a setup link. Open that email on another device (or print it) so you can scan it with the phone you'll use in Korea.

3 Route A — Install & enable

Settings → Cellular → Add eSIM → scan the QR. Enable it on landing and set it as your Cellular Data line. If you'll hotspot a laptop, switch on Personal Hotspot in settings and test it.

4 Route B — Airport unlimited SIM

Go to the Incheon arrivals telecom counter (locations in Section 3) and ask for the unlimited 30-day prepaid plan (script below). Before paying, confirm the high-speed threshold, then staff activate it on the spot — test tethering before you leave the counter.

05 Korean Script for the Clerk

• AT THE PREPAID COUNTER

30일 무제한 데이터 선불 요금제 있어요? 제일 빠른 걸로 주세요.

Sam-sib-il mu-je-han de-i-teo seon-bul yo-geum-je iss-eo-yo? Je-il ppa-reun geol-lo ju-se-yo.

"Do you have a 30-day unlimited-data prepaid plan? I'd like the fastest one."

• CHECKING TETHERING

테더링(핫스팟) 되나요?

Te-deo-ring (hat-seu-pat) doe-na-yo?

"Does tethering (hotspot) work on this plan?"

06 Insider Warnings & Hidden Costs

⚠️ **"Unlimited" often means unlimited-then-throttled.** Even premium plans may slow tethering after a high threshold. Ask specifically about the hotspot cap if you plan to work off your phone.

⚠️ **Airport SIM ≠ verification-ready number.** A passport-registered prepaid number generally won't pass Korean bank / PASS identity verification. Fine for calls, texts, and KakaoTalk; not for opening Korean financial accounts.

⚠️ **One line per passport (2026 rule)** applies to the prepaid route.

⚠️ **Unlimited eSIM has no number at all** — pure data. Pick the route that matches whether you need a number.

Information last verified: 2026-07-13 · Prices & terms change often — confirm at the source before publishing.

Medium Stay · ARC Soon · Unlimited Data

The classic "bridge." Get this right and you won't pay twice.

STAY
1–6 months

ARC
Coming soon

DATA
Unlimited

PHONE
Own phone

BUDGET
Medium · ₩15–40k

01 Your Custom Plan Strategy

You'll be here for months and you want a **real Korean number** eventually (for KakaoTalk, banking OTP, the PASS app) — but that number legally needs your **physical ARC**, still 2–6 weeks out. So the plan has two phases.

Phase 1 (now, no ARC): get online with a data eSIM — no wasted contract. **Phase 2 (ARC arrives):** move to an MVNO (알뜰폰) postpaid plan for a proper 010 number and unlimited-style data at a low monthly price, on the same SKT/KT/LG U+ towers.

RECOMMENDED ROUTE

Bridge → MVNO postpaid

브릿지 → 알뜰폰 후불

₩ EST. COST

₩20,000–40,000

≈ \$15–30 · per month, phase 2

DIFFICULTY

Medium



⌚ SETUP

1–2 phases

⚠ **Heads-up** — A passport-registered prepaid line CANNOT be upgraded to postpaid — you'll get a NEW number when you sign with your ARC. To keep one number, start data-only (nothing to lose) or use a bridge product that converts an eSIM into postpaid.

02 Required Documents



Phase 1 — unlocked, eSIM phone + card

For the data eSIM while you wait



Phase 2 — Alien Registration Card (ARC)

외국인등록증 · mandatory for any postpaid line



Phase 2 — Korean bank account

For monthly auto-debit (some MVNOs accept a card)



Phase 2 — Passport + proof of address

Identity cross-check; lease/utility bill occasionally requested

03 Providers & Exactly Where to Go

Chingu Mobile chingumobile.com

English-speaking team, online order with Seoul pickup; well-known foreigner plans (e.g. ~₩20,900/mo, 11GB + ongoing reduced-speed data).

EG SIM Card egsimcard.com

KT-network, English app and support.

Kimchi Mobile kimchimobile.com

Foreigner reseller offering a bridge eSIM → KT postpaid conversion — data now, 010 number added once your ARC is ready. Sidesteps the number-change problem.

MVNO Hub (gov't comparison) mvnohub.kr

Official 알뜰폰 comparison for all budget carriers.

📍 Phase 1 is in-app. Phase 2 is online sign-up (English brands above) or Seoul pickup, after your ARC and Korean bank account are ready.

04 Step-by-Step Action Plan

1 Today (no ARC) — get online

Install a data eSIM now (follow the install steps in Guide #1 or #2). This keeps you connected while you wait for your ARC.

2 Consider a bridge product

If you want your eventual number tied to one clean account, look at Kimchi Mobile's bridge plan (kimchimobile.com): it starts as a data eSIM and converts to a KT postpaid line — adding your real 010 number — once your ARC and Korean bank account are ready. Read the conversion terms (timeframe and discount) before committing.

3 Collect your ARC

Pick up your Alien Registration Card at your immigration appointment (book through HiKorea). Check that the name printed on the card matches your passport exactly — mismatches are the number-one cause of PASS-app problems later.

4 Open a Korean bank account

You'll need this for MVNO auto-debit. Bring your ARC and passport to a bank branch to open an account.

5 Sign up for the MVNO plan

On chingumobile.com (English), browse the plans, pick an unlimited-style option, and start the order — the site walks you through each step in English.

6 Verify with ARC & activate

Complete the foreigner (ARC) identity-verification step, set up auto-pay from your Korean account, and receive/insert the SIM (or activate the converted line). Activation typically takes 1–2 business days, after which your 010 number is live.

05 Korean Script for the Clerk

• AT THE BANK

외국인등록증으로 통장(계좌) 만들고 싶어요.

Oe-gug-in-deung-nok-jeung-eu-ro tong-jang (gye-jwa) man-deul-go sip-eo-yo.

"I'd like to open a bank account with my Alien Registration Card."

• CONFIRMING THE NEW NUMBER

외국인등록증으로 후불 요금제 개통할게요. 번호는 새로 받는 거죠?

Oe-gug-in-deung-nok-jeung-eu-ro hu-bul yo-geum-je gae-tong-hal-ge-yo. Beon-ho-neun sae-ro bat-neun geo-jyo?

"I'll activate a postpaid plan with my ARC. I'll be getting a new number, right?"

06 Insider Warnings & Hidden Costs

⚠ **Prepaid → postpaid means a new number.** If keeping one number matters, start data-only (eSIM) or use a bridge product. Don't build your KakaoTalk / bank on a temporary prepaid number you'll lose.

⚠ **The PASS app + foreign names.** As of mid-2026, PASS still has known issues with names containing hyphens, apostrophes, or special characters. Make sure your carrier registration matches your ARC/passport exactly; if PASS fails, call your carrier (114) and ask them to read back the stored name.

⚠ **Immigration database lag.** Right after receiving or renewing an ARC, the carrier's system may briefly show it unverified. If verification fails, contact your carrier and the 1345 Immigration Contact Center. Timeframes vary — don't assume a fixed number of days.

⚠ **MVNO interfaces can be Korean-only.** Stick to the foreigner-focused brands above for English support.

Information last verified: 2026-07-13 · Prices & terms change often — confirm at the source before publishing.

Long Stay · Has ARC · New Phone · Premium

The one profile where a big-three device contract truly fits.

STAY
6+ months

ARC
Yes

DATA
Heavy · 10–50GB

PHONE
Buying here

BUDGET
Premium · ₩70k+

01 Your Custom Plan Strategy

You're settling in, you already hold your ARC, you use a lot of data, and you want a **new phone** — with budget to match. This is the one profile where the **big-three carriers (SKT, KT, LG U+)** with a **device contract** genuinely make sense: strongest network, a new handset over 24 months, and full verification-ready service.

A premium 5G plan runs ~₩89,000/month for true-unlimited 5G, with the phone added as a monthly installment (higher tiers often lower the device cost via subsidies). Ask the store to split the plan fee and the phone installment on paper.

RECOMMENDED ROUTE

Big-3 carrier + device contract

통신 3사 + 단말기 약정

₩ EST. COST

₩70,000–95,000+

≈ \$53–72+ · per month + device

DIFFICULTY

Medium

● ● ○

⌚ SETUP

~1–2 hrs

△ **Heads-up** — You're paying the premium path by choice. Once the phone is paid off, moving the SIM to an MVNO (알뜰폰) can cut the monthly cost 30–50% on the same network — worth revisiting after 24 months.

02 Required Documents



Alien Registration Card (ARC)

외국인등록증 · mandatory for any device contract, no exceptions



Passport

Identity cross-check



Korean bank account

For auto-debit; device installments rarely accepted on a card alone



Proof of address + deposit

Lease/utility bill (original). LG U+ charges ~₩30,000 deposit if ARC expires ≤12 months

03 Providers & Exactly Where to Go

SK Telecom (SKT) T World · Gangnam/Itaewon/Hongdae

Widest coverage, strongest signal in Seoul & on KTX. English-capable T World flagship stores.

KT globalshop.kt.com

Strong foreigner support; KT Plaza "global stores" have English-speaking staff.

LG U+ lguplus.com/korea-sim/eng

Most onboarding-friendly online: multilingual app (EN/中文/Tiếng Việt/Tagalog) and online signup. 1,200+ branches accept foreign ID.

📍 Go to an official carrier store — ideally an English-capable flagship — not a random back-street phone shop.

04 Step-by-Step Action Plan

1 Shortlist a handset + plan

Decide on the carrier and the phone together, since the monthly figure combines the plan fee and the device installment. Browse the carrier's foreigner / English site first to see current handsets and premium 5G tiers.

2 Go to an official flagship with your documents

Head to an official carrier store — an English-capable flagship such as SKT in Gangnam/Itaewon/Hongdae, a KT Plaza "global store," or an LG U+ branch (use the store locator on globalshop.kt.com or the carrier's site). Bring the full document set from Section 2.

3 Choose a premium 5G unlimited plan

Pick a top-tier 5G unlimited plan. Crucially, ask the staff to write the plan fee and the phone installment separately on the quote so you can see each part — don't accept a single bundled number.

4 Real-name verification with your ARC

Staff scan your ARC and passport into the KCC real-name system on their terminal; approval usually takes under a minute and ends with a "verified / 인증완료" confirmation.

5 Deposit & auto-pay

Set up auto-pay from your Korean bank account and confirm the deposit amount (often ~₩30,000 if your ARC expires within 12 months) and exactly how it's refunded.

6 Sign & receive the phone

Review the contract summary — check the contract term (usually 24 months) and the early-termination fee — then sign and get your phone set up on the spot. Save every document: the contract, plan sheet, device installment schedule, and your customer number.

05 Korean Script for the Clerk

• OPENING WITH A DEVICE

외국인등록증 있어요. 5G 무제한 요금제로 새 휴대폰이랑 같이 개통하고 싶어요.

Oe-gug-in-deung-nok-jeung iss-eo-yo. O-ji-i mu-je-han yo-geum-je-ro sae hyu-dae-pon-i-rang ga-chi gae-tong-ha-go sip-eo-yo.

"I have my ARC. I'd like to activate a 5G unlimited plan together with a new phone."

• ITEMIZE THE COST

요금제 요금이랑 단말기 할부금 따로 알려주세요.

Yo-geum-je yo-geum-i-rang dan-mal-gi hal-bu-geum tta-ro al-lyeo-ju-se-yo.

"Please tell me the plan fee and the phone installment separately."

• TERM & PENALTIES

약정 기간이 몇 개월이에요? 위약금은 얼마예요?

Yak-jeong gi-gan-i myeot gae-wol-i-e-yo? Wi-yak-geum-eun eol-ma-ye-yo?

"How long is the contract, and what is the early-termination fee?"

• THE DEPOSIT

외국인 보증금이 필요하면 얼마고, 환불은 어떻게 받나요?

Oe-gug-in bo-jeung-geum-i pil-yo-ha-myeon eol-ma-go, hwan-bul-eun eo-tteo-ke bat-na-yo?

"If a foreigner deposit is required, how much is it and how is it refunded?"

06 Insider Warnings & Hidden Costs

 **The device installment is a separate 24-month debt.** If you leave Korea early, the remaining phone balance plus an early-termination fee (often ~₩30,000 on the line, plus the outstanding device cost) can come due. Understand both before signing.

 **Deposit for foreigners is normal — and refundable.** Expect ~₩30,000 if your ARC expires within 12 months. Refunds usually need a Korean bank account; if you close it, get the refund at the original branch.

 **Foreign cards may be declined for postpaid.** Some carrier billing systems reject non-Korean cards for auto-pay. A Korean bank account is the reliable route.

 **PASS app + foreign names** can still misbehave with hyphens/apostrophes/special characters as of mid-2026 — make sure your registered name matches your ARC exactly.